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Bigfoot and Freedom: A Sociocultural Analysis

In the 21st century, despite the rapid expansion of information, we have not solved the mystery of the creature known as Bigfoot, yet the creature 's credibility does continue to fade as science progresses. In the past five years, interest in such mysterious creatures has surged while websites bring science to remote mountains. Unlike other paranormal phenomena that have raised but lost interest such as the Goatman or Yeti, Bigfoot culture remains remarkably resilient, attracting new generations of enthusiasts and self-proclaimed "researchers."

This essay explores a unique perspective—the parallel between Bigfoot as a cultural symbol and humanity's endless pursuit of freedom. This essay does not seek to establish a symbolic connection between Bigfoot and freedom. Instead, through the lens of the study of the phenomenon, it explores the systematic categorized similarities in how humans pursue freedom and mystery in different representations.

Part I. Bigfoot's Cultural Symbolism and the Metaphor of Freedom

Throughout various cultures, mysteries concerning wild men and bigfoots have been integral to folklore and mythology. From the Yeti of the Himalayas to North America's Sasquatch, these beings transcend geographical boundaries while maintaining core

similarities. They exist on the fringes of human civilization, occupying a liminal space that represents what humanity has ostensibly left behind. Historically, numerous individuals have reported encounters with these mysterious creatures, some even claiming close interactions or confrontations. However, despite the plethora of "eyewitness" accounts, the scientific community has yet to procure definitive evidence, such as a living or deceased specimen, to substantiate Bigfoot's existence.

Bigfoot, as a cultural symbol, embodies the idea of an “untamed existence” that modern humans have sacrificed in their pursuit of civilization. This creature represents a state unbound by social constraints, technology, or the intricate web of cultural expectations. The parallels with freedom are striking—both symbolize an ideal that humanity longs for but has seemingly relinquished in the process of constructing modern society. As *The Oregon Encyclopedia* suggests, “Like salmon, Bigfoot has become an important symbolic resource through which many Oregonians and Northwest residents have defined their identities and considered their place in the natural world.” Salmon, of course, has real material-value, but perhaps the tale of Bigfoot has value as an explanation of freedom. In this way, Bigfoot is more than just a cryptid. It is a projection of human desire for an alternative existence, to be free from the demands and limitations of society.

In an era where satellite imaging can unveil every corner of the planet, why does the myth of the undiscovered continue to captivate us? One possible explanation lies in semiotic theory—the way symbols acquire meaning within a cultural framework. The French sociologist Pierre Bourdieu's concept of "symbolic power" suggests that such

myths shape and reflect collective beliefs, reinforcing social structures while also providing an outlet for alternative identities and desires. Joshua Blu Buhs (2009), in his comprehensive cultural analysis "Bigfoot: The Life and Times of a Legend," argues that Bigfoot functions as "a potent sign within American mythology that reflects shifting anxieties about wilderness, technology, and human identity in modern society" (p. 187).

This idea is not unique to Bigfoot. Haruki Murakami's short story *The Elephant Vanishes* presents a similar phenomenon: a mysterious disappearance that defies logical explanation yet becomes a lasting part of a community's collective memory. In Murakami's story, a town's elephant vanishes without a trace, leaving residents with only an unsolvable mystery and a lingering sense of loss. Much like Bigfoot, the missing elephant becomes more than just an event; it turns into a cultural artifact, a symbol of something both forgotten and longed for. The invisible nature of such myths suggests that societies need these enigmas—not because they expect resolution, but because the unknown provides a space for speculation, identity formation, and reflection on what has been lost in the march of progress.

Thus, the legend of Bigfoot persists not just as a cryptozoological curiosity but as a parallel to humanity's endless quest for freedom. The pursuit itself reveals striking similarities: both Bigfoot and absolute freedom remain perpetually beyond our grasp, yet we continue to search for both with unwavering determination. Just as Bigfoot researchers venture into remote wilderness with cameras and recording devices, philosophers and revolutionaries throughout history have ventured into uncharted intellectual and social territories, seeking evidence of a freedom that exists beyond

societal expectations, technological oversight, and institutional control if those worms are tested.

In both pursuits, the object of desire represents something untamed, uncategorized, and not fully understood by conventional frameworks. The footprints of Bigfoot and the traces of absolute freedom are approaching the same quality. They imply possibility rather than certainty, encouraging continued exploration rather than eventual capture of the only "truth." In this way, the persistent chase itself becomes as meaningful as any potential discovery.

Part II. The Untamed State of Existence

In contrast to many mythical creatures associated with malevolence, Bigfoot is often depicted as neutral or even benevolent, existing independently and desiring only solitude. This portrayal stands in stark contrast to entities like the Wendigo, a supernatural being rooted in Algonquian folklore. Traditionally, the Wendigo is described as a malevolent, cannibalistic spirit that can possess humans, leading them to commit acts of murder and cannibalism. According to legend, individuals became Wendigos after resorting to cannibalism during harsh winters, embodying insatiable greed and the darkest aspects of human nature.

Jean-Jacques Rousseau's concept of the "natural man" further illuminates this symbolism. Rousseau posited that humans, in their primal state, were pure and free, unburdened by the artificial constructs of civilization. In works such as *Emile*, he discusses the assimilation to social norms that some children may choose. He distinguished between education, which aims to develop an individual's potential, and

domestication, which suppresses and reshapes natural instincts to fit societal norms. In Rousseau's view, modern humans have been domesticated, losing their original purity in exchange for structured existence.

While both Bigfoot and the Wendigo reside on the fringes of human civilization, their symbolic meanings diverge sharply. As Carlson (2009) documents in his ethnohistorical study of northern Alberta, the Wendigo was not merely folklore but had tangible social consequences, as evidenced in the well-documented Swift Runner case of 1879, where a Cree trapper was executed after killing and consuming his family members during a harsh winter—an act attributed to Wendigo possession (p. 357). In contrast, Bigfoot is rarely associated with such malevolence. Though some legends suggest it may be responsible for human disappearances or deaths in the wilderness, in certain cultural narratives, Bigfoot is still believed to guide lost children back to safety or serve as a spiritual entity in the mysterious world. This duality sets it apart from Wendigo, whose mythos is fundamentally rooted in fear and destruction.

This discussion of crime aligns with Michel Foucault's concept of disciplinary power, which posits that modern society maintains control through mechanisms of surveillance, normalization, and self-regulation. In his seminal work "Discipline and Punish," Foucault argued that institutions such as schools, prisons, and hospitals function as instruments of social control, shaping individuals' behavior to conform to societal norms. Marano (1982) extends this framework to cultural narratives in his comprehensive analysis of Wendigo phenomena, observing that "mythological constructs often serve as powerful mechanisms of social control in pre-industrial societies, establishing behavioral boundaries through fear rather than formal institutional structures" (p. 390). In this

context, the Wendigo myth can be seen as a tool for reinforcing social boundaries, warning against the dangers of deviating from accepted behaviors. Bigfoot, conversely, symbolizes what remains untamed—existing beyond the reach of such societal regulation.

Echoing such a statement, Bigfoot represents an entity that remains outside the realm of domestication, retaining an uncorrupted form of freedom. Bigfoot offers a vision of an existence that is autonomous, self-sustaining, and ultimately beyond civilization's reach. Have you ever thought about the freedom which could never be attained in such a world?

Part III. The Freedom That Cannot Be Attained

Freedom, like the elusive Bigfoot, represents a state that humans constantly pursue yet never fully capture. This extends to Schopenhauer's philosophy of perpetual desire and suffering, in which he argues that human life consists of an endless cycle of wanting, temporary satisfaction, and renewed longing. As Schopenhauer states in *The World as Will and Representation*, "Every attained desire gives birth to a new one, and so on endlessly" (Schopenhauer 196). In this framework, absolute freedom functions as an unattainable ideal, something that can be glimpsed but never truly held. Much like Bigfoot, it appears only in traces, leaving behind footprints of possibility but never offering definitive proof as a state of being or life plan.

The paradox of freedom lies in its self-limiting nature. Absolute freedom would require the absence of all constraints, yet human existence is inherently constrained by biological needs, social structures, and others. This contradiction aligns with the

Hegelian view that freedom is not a static endpoint but rather an evolving process. In *Elements of the Philosophy of Right*, Hegel asserts that "freedom is the recognition of necessity" (Hegel 32). He claims that true freedom is found not in the absence of limits, but in understanding and working within them. If this is true, then complete freedom, like the mythical Bigfoot, may remain an abstraction rather than a reality, which could never be attained by human beings.

Just as the debate over Bigfoot's existence continues, so too does the discussion about the nature of freedom. As a biological entity, Bigfoot would require a stable population, genetic diversity, and physical evidence—bones, hair, scat, or remnants of habitation to sustain its existence over centuries. Yet, no verifiable trace has ever been found. From a biological and sociological perspective, the absence of these fundamental markers makes Bigfoot's existence highly improbable.

Similarly, freedom cannot exist in a vacuum; it requires a framework against which it can be defined, understood, and challenged. Without constraints, there are no boundaries to push against, no structures to break free from. A framework is necessary, not as a constraint, but as a point of reference that defines its boundaries. Without limits, freedom would dissolve into abstraction, unrecognizable and unattainable.

Part IV. Freedom Within Frameworks

Freedom is often misunderstood as the absence of all constraints, yet this perception fails to recognize that everything requires structure. Immanuel Kant argues that genuine freedom is not boundless indulgence but the ability to act according to rational moral law. In *Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals*, Kant asserts that freedom is realized

not through the rejection of rules but through self-determined adherence to universal principles. He introduces the categorical imperative, a concept that dictates moral action should be guided by laws that could be universally applied. Only by aligning personal will with rational, self-imposed duty does one attain authentic autonomy (Kant 88). Thus, freedom is not an absence of limitations but the conscious choice to follow moral law out of rational self-discipline.

Kant argues that only beings capable of rational self-governance can be truly free. While non-rational entities act out of necessity or desire, humans, through reason, are capable of transcending instinctual drives and choosing actions based on moral duty and reason. This self-imposed discipline does not diminish freedom but rather makes it possible. Without it, what is mistaken for freedom is merely enslavement to arbitrary whims or external influences. True autonomy is not a retreat from responsibility but an engagement with a structured moral order. It is not found in lawlessness but in the conscious ability to act in accordance with reason.

Nietzsche's concept of the *Übermensch* expands this idea, emphasizing that freedom is not about abandoning order but about transcending imposed values to create new ones. In *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, Nietzsche argues that human beings should strive for continuous self-overcoming, rather than settling into complacency or nihilistic rebellion (Nietzsche 134). His vision does not advocate reckless liberation but rather an ascent, the movement toward higher forms of existence that demand personal strength, self-mastery, responsibility and excellence. Freedom is not a retreat into instinct or a descent into chaos but an expansion toward self-realization and autonomy.

In a modern, pluralistic world, the frameworks that define freedom are no longer singular or absolute. The contemporary individual is shaped by a multitude of intersecting forces—economic structures, digital identities, shifting moral codes—each imposing its own form of constraint. Yet, rather than rendering freedom meaningless, this complexity demands new forms of self-determination. Freedom is neither static nor universal but an ongoing process of reinterpretation and transformation, where the individual is both bound by frameworks and capable of reshaping them.

Part V. Meaning of Freedom in Modern Context

In contemporary society, both Bigfoot and freedom function as powerful symbols that help us navigate existential challenges. Erich Fromm, in *Escape from Freedom*, describes the modern dilemma: while individuals have gained unprecedented external freedoms, they have simultaneously lost a sense of belonging and security, resulting in existential anxiety and loneliness (Fromm 32). He distinguishes between "negative freedom", the ability to be free from external constraints, and "positive freedom", the ability to actively shape one's life and realize personal potential (Fromm 40). The comparison of the two concepts is crucial to understanding the symbolic power of freedom. Freedom exists in two dimensions at the same time, it is not bound by social consensus within the structure, and at the same time it can exist freely outside the structure of reality.

Another philosopher, Isaiah Berlin, expands on this duality in "*Two Concepts of Liberty*," he argues that negative freedom, the absence of external interference, is essential, yet insufficient on its own. True freedom requires a balance between being free from

restrictions and having the capacity to act meaningfully within a structured world (Berlin 16). The internationalization and digital age have changed our concept of freedom, but it has not eliminated this dynamic equilibrium. Despite the ever-changing cultural, political, and technological landscape, fundamental aspirations remain steady. We aspire to decide on our own existence while maintaining meaningful connections. Similarly, Bigfoot's narrative has evolved with the development of technology and media, but has retained its essential characteristics as an entity that exists outside the sight of society, and our quest for this image has led us to believe in their existence and to continue to explore and research.

Bigfoot, like freedom, is a subject to balance. We don't want to break frames, and sometimes we even want to rebuild them. Nor is freedom entirely extreme, and in an increasingly pluralistic world, we must question the certainty of fixed truths, acknowledging that freedom is neither singular nor absolute. Conversely, freedom may be a middle point, the pole in the middle of the scale. While Bigfoot's existence is extreme in its isolation, stories about him must serve the purpose of defining the boundary between the wilderness world and the world of human settlements. Perhaps we position freedom and structure as opposing forces only because we fail to perceive the delicate equilibrium that sustains both. What appears as tension may actually be symbiosis — an invisible but necessary balance that societies naturally evolve toward, even as individuals struggle to articulate its nature.

Part VI. Conclusion

We are not emphasizing the achievement of Bigfoot's negative freedom social state on the material level, but rather exploring the framework of social freedom to achieve the positive freedom as I discussed above.

René Descartes' methodic doubt serves as a model for exploring the unknown by questioning everything, we seek certainty. Descartes argued that "if you would be a real seeker after truth, it is necessary that at least once in your life you doubt, as far as possible, all things" (Descartes, Principles of Philosophy 5). Even though Bigfoot remains unproven, we must continue to approach the unknown with curiosity. Similarly, no one has yet been able to fully define or prove the existence of absolute freedom. We continue to live, to learn, and to strive toward the ideal of the known, always pushing the boundaries of the frameworks that confine us, toward a future yet to be discovered.

We cannot see everything, and there is everything there for us to perceive. Freedom and order are not opposites. Order creates the space where freedom can thrive, while freedom gives purpose to structure the order. Just like the ever-elusive Bigfoot, the unknown will always exceed what is known, and grow in the well-known judgement and expectation.

Our quest continues, not to chase some kind of myth, but to understand our place in the world. Fortunately, we are chasing our own existence and freedom, not being hunted down, nor do we need to prove that there is no existence such as Bigfoot nowadays.

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